very accurate, though it almost immediately destroyed the Drokung Samba Bridge. This effectively isolated the Assam Rifles position from the Grenadiers, for the bulk of the defences at the bridge were located on the east bank.

At 4.30 a.m. the mortar and artillery barrage was lifted and Chinese infantry closed in on No. 5 Platoon. The fighting was intense, with Chinese superiority in numbers making the vital difference. The platoon commander, Havildar Som Bahadur, and twenty other riflemen were killed and an equal number wounded. After two hours of bitter fighting and with ammunition running out, the Chinese overran the platoon shortly after first light. This brought them into contact with the other two platoons which carried on fighting equally tenaciously despite the Chinese attacking from the north, west and east. Another three hours of fighting, this time in broad daylight, saw both the section commanders, Subedar Hem Lal and Naib Subedar Shamsher Bahadur Thapa fall to Chinese bullets along with another thirty-six other ranks. Rifleman Bishan Singh, the LMG detachment commander of No. 2 Platoon, was blasted out of his position by a Chinese rocket fired at him. Despite being severely wounded and having lost his weapon in the explosion, the soldier jumped into another LMG pit and continued fighting from there. Once his ammunition was expended, Bishan Singh managed to escape from the post and made it back to Zimithang. The commanding officer of 5 Assam Rifles, Rattan Singh, was wounded and along with H. P. Singh and twenty-three other survivors, was taken prisoner. By 9.30 a.m., Khenzemane was in Chinese hands.

With the Chinese pushing hard on the east bank as well, and the company commander, Lieutenant G .V. P. Rao, having fallen, survivors from 4 Grenadiers at Drokung Samba Bridge started to fall back along the track towards Zimithang, which was about a two-hour march downriver. Two platoons from Bravo Company of 4 Garhwal Rifles were deployed at Chutangmu, which was located between Khenzemane and Zimithang, for the protection of Division HQ. After a brief firefight with the advancing Chinese, the Garhwalis fell back on Zimithang, acting as a rearguard for the retreating men of Assam Rifles and 4 Grenadiers. Niranjan Prasad, seeing the survivors arriving, was only just beginning to grasp the magnitude of what had happened on the Nam Ka Chu: ‘Stragglers and walking wounded from Khenzemane and Drokung Samba Bridge began to arrive, followed a little later by escapees from Khenzemane. I was glad to see there was no